

## FMAC TASK 1

**1. INT. SUBURBUN HOUSE, SMALL LIVING ROOM - EVENING**

A man sits on a recliner in a dim, sombre living room. He wears a stained white tank-top, and beige canvas pants that are a size too small. Adjusting himself on the seat, he clutches a beer, takes a sip as he switches on his CRT television.

**ANCHOR 1 (ON T.V)**

Good Evening- tonight the world has reason to celebrate. The Hermians have officially eradicated cancer worldwide, the last known case in Somalia was neutralized mere hours ago.

The T.V cuts to the other end of the table, another anchor is sitting, he holds some kind of document in his hand.

**ANCHOR 2 (ON T.V)**

It's wonderful, isn't it? 7 years have graced us since The First Contact, and innumerable lives have been saved due to the noble charity and benevolence of our Overseers. Humanity as a whole ...

**CUT TO:**

**2. INT. SUBURBUN HOUSE, KITCHEN - EVENING**

Water gushes from the kitchen tap. A boy no older than eighteen scrubs the dishes, he overhears the news channel, and pauses for a moment eyes fixated on the running water. After a moment, he shuts off the tap and drifts towards the living room.

**3. INT. SUBURBUN HOUSE, SMALL LIVING ROOM - EVENING**

The boy takes a seat adjacent to the man watching the report.

**ROBERT**

How the hell did you ever live without them.

**MICHEAL**

We didn't have much, but we didn't need much either. Honestly, I think you have it worse than I do.

**ROBERT**

Obviously not. You're forgetting how it was before. I haven't been sick since I was 9, we haven't had to worry about welfare aid, that surgery they did on your liver saved your life. I just wish you'd stay in step with the rest of us. I don't like it when you reminicse of a rougher time.

**MICHEAL**

You don't get it, what I'm trying to say is..

**ROBERT**

(snaps)

I do get it. You think I'm naive and impulsive, but I've thought this through.

(pauses)

Next year, when I'm old enough... I'm going to apply to the Federation.

MICHEAL is lost for words, he places his beer down on the coffee table.

**ROBERT**

They've done more for us in 5 years than our leaders have done in decades. Look around- the world's better with them Dad.

**MICHEAL**

(pensive)

Nothing comes for free.

**ROBERT**

Joining the Federation will give me purpose, aren't you the one always nagging me about planning my future.

**MICHEAL**

Purpose? Don't twist my words. I meant college... or joining me at the garage.

**ROBERT**

(raises voice)

This is what I mean Dad. Nobody needs a mechanic anymore, nobody needs college. What's left for us? They don't just know more than us... They know everything.

We look around the house. Everything seems ordinary, stuck in a 1990s comfort. We can hear the clock ticks, the T. V buzzes in the background. ROBERT rises, and pulls on the curtains. The sight that greets us is anything but ordinary. Men and women with mechanical body modifications wander the street. Nature and greenery have been replaced: the most prominent color is a metallic gray which blankets the landscape. On the road, there are no cars of the regular kind, they are replaced by sleek hovering vehicles which seem to use magnets to produce momentum

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**ROBERT**

You tell me Dad. Where in a world like that does a car mechanic fit. What college degree is gonna teach me all of that in 4 years. You have to face the truth at some point. We've become outdated, obsolete. Joining the Federation is the only way I can feel like I matter.

**MICHEAL**

Don't you dare call your own people obsolete. We're not outdated because those aliens can build some shiny toys and hovercars.

**ROBERT**

You know we're not supposed to call them that, Dad. This is what I don't get about you. Why do we even own a TV? Neural interfaces are cheap enough—we could get the news straight to our brains. Why do I need to wash the dishes when everything could be automated?

**MICHEAL**

This is our planet. I'll call them whatever I want. Every disease they cure, every plate they fill, every life they save. It comes with a price, it reminds us of their power, their presence on this planet. They're buying you off one by one. Shaping you.

MICHEAL directs ROBERT to look out the window this time.

**MICHEAL**

I know what you see. A utopia. A world that will soon have never known suffering. But look closer, what's the last time you saw someone paint something, even graffiti on the wall, what's the last time you listened to a song that a Robot didn't compose for you. What's the last real idea that came from us.

ROBERT looks a little uneasy.

**ROBERT**

Maybe... We don't need that anymore. Creativity... We used to need that sure- when there was struggle on this planet, when people needed something to hold onto. But now...

(MORE)

**ROBERT (CONT'D)**

now we've got it all. Songs, paintings, stories they're a relic of the past. Their machines can do them better than we ever did, and that's what matters. Perfection.

(he falters, searching for certainty)

It's out there, and it exists. People can listen, or look, or feel something. Not everything needs to be born out of an emotion. It's nice enough that They created these machines for us, you should be grateful for it.

**MICHEAL**

Don't be dazzled by these tricks, son. It's soulless, you tell me this counterfeit music moves you. But tell me this, does it move them? Have you ever seen an alien love? Grieve? Laugh? A race of beings that could never understand what it's like to be us, could never rule over us. You think you're enjoying it, but what you feel is a distraction. A performance made to keep you quiet while they tighten the leash on us.

**ROBERT**

(accusing)

You're being paranoid. Everyone's safer, healthier, and richer than ever. I want to join the Federation so it stays that way. So what if they're not like us? That's the point. If people like me work with them, maybe they'll start to understand us better. Isn't this the future you wanted for me: one where I can actually help build a better world for everyone?

**MICHEAL**

The future I wanted for you was one where you lived. Not existed... In some polished cage, as an alien dictator's lapdog.

ROBERT pauses, he reflects on his dad's words.

**ROBERT**

Whether you like it or not Dad. This is progress, They gave it to us when our leaders couldn't.

MICHEAL looks lost, he doesn't understand how to get his point across to his son.

**MICHEAL**

Progress? You call this progress?  
What do they teach kids in school,  
Robert. They don't teach you how to  
think, they teach you how to obey.  
They made it so easy for us to stop  
being human, and that's the genius of  
it, you won't see shackles, you won't  
see the bars. There's no warden  
barking orders. That's because they  
don't need one. In half a decade,  
they built a world where obedience  
feels natural. We're not a people  
anymore. We're a workforce. Eager.  
Grateful. A slave race that doesn't  
know it's been enslaved.

**ROBERT**

(firm, but shaken)  
You're exaggerating. Nobody's forcing  
us into anything. Not a single  
perso...

MICHEAL cuts off ROBERT

**MICHEAL**

That's exactly what they want you to  
say. You think peace is the same as  
freedom. It isn't. Peace without  
choice is just control.

**ROBERT**

That's not true. I chose this Dad. It  
was my decision to apply to the  
Federation.

**MICHEAL**

You call it a choice? I call it  
programming. Tell me, son. When's the  
last time you saw a protest? A  
strike? A politician that wasn't just  
parroting what the Hermians already  
said? You can't remember, can you?

**ROBERT**

(quiet, faltering)  
Maybe because there's nothing to  
protest anymore.

MICHEAL gestures towards the window again.

**MICHEAL**

That's not a utopia. That's a museum.  
Every one of us on display.  
(MORE)

**MICHEAL (CONT'D)**

Dedicating ourselves to service.  
Those people... They'll live a long  
life. Healthy. Without any stress.  
But was it worth it?

The two sit in silence, only the faint hum of the CRT and the buzz of the hovering cars outside filling the air. ROBERT averts his gaze, his jaw tightens, while MICHEAL leans forward, eyes fixed on his son.